

World Cup, where the side fell to Australia in the semifinal. After a frustrating Schrödinger's Cat-like situation, the national call-ups dried up, and a fast bowler once viewed as a bridge between the Jhulan Goswami era and a new generation of pace development suddenly vanished from the scene.

Life of a cricket nomad

For Shikha, cricket is cricket, no matter the level at which it is played. She plunged into the life of a cricket nomad, playing in the Women's Big Bash League in Australia, the Super Smash in New Zealand with the Canterbury Magicians, and the Women's Caribbean Premier League. In the 2025 edition, she topped the wicket charts for Trinbago Knight Riders with five wickets in four games at an economy of 6.73. She was joint third overall.

Apart from her solid stewardship of the Goan women's team in the past and for Baroda now in the domestic circuit, where Shikha consistently impressed with bat and ball, she is also the most successful Indian pacer in the WPL, taking 30 wickets in 27 games at an economy rate of 6.96 for the Delhi Capitals. Overall, Mumbai Indians' Nat Sciver-Brunt tops the list with 32 scalps. The next best Indian quick is Arundhati Reddy with 14 wickets from 20 matches.

For anyone else, those numbers would be contract-clinching. But Shikha decided to attend trials ahead of the WPL 2026 Mega Auction, trying out for her native State's franchise, the UP Warriorz.

"I had never attended a trial before, and I was excited about it, having heard so much from my Goa teammates. I would always ask players how their trials went. DC once held trials, and I asked Coach Jonathan Batty if I could participate and practise there since it was raining in Goa. I got to go to

Bengaluru, it was just open nets then. I've never been on the receiving end, but I got a chance with UP Warriorz in Mumbai," Shikha tells *Sportstar*.

"A lot of people specifically say the first day of trials is bad, and I got to experience that. We had simulation games, and I was captain of my side on both days. Abhishek (Nayar) goes into so much detail. Sneha Rana was there too, and she's just won the World Cup," she adds.

The Warriorz clearly liked what they saw, given that they bid a hefty Rs. 2.4 crore for the medium pacer.

"She is an experienced player, and we wanted her experience of having played in high-pressure tournaments. Her numbers in the WPL are the best among Indian pace bowlers in the last three years, be it in the powerplay or death overs. We wanted experience in those aspects," head coach Nayar explained.

"I wasn't following the auction too intensely, but I had to when my mom spotted my name. I genuinely don't care about price tags; people won't believe it. I am just happy that I am valued and that there was a bidding war for my services between RCB and UP," she remembers.

It helps that Shikha is also a solid bat. In the domestic circuit, she is known for her grind in the middle. Internationally, too, she has been part of several crucial batting efforts since the early 2010s.

"I love batting. For my State, I would bat at four, middle order. Unless you're, I guess, Jasprit Bumrah, it would be hard for someone in this age to be a pure bowler and survive. W.V. Raman sir always used to say that the runs bowlers get you are the ones that will win you games. If I am just a bowler, someone else who can contribute 15+ runs more than I can will get importance. It's not sad, it's how competitive cricket has rightly gotten."



At the Delhi Capitals in particular, Shikha had the pick of some of the world's best to bounce ideas off, from Meg Lanning, who will join her at the Warriorz, and Annabel Sutherland, to Jemimah Rodrigues.

"As a bowler, it's really nice to understand what the batter is thinking. In the nets, you bowl and get feedback about whether they could see my slower ball coming out of my hand, or if they were able to counter me easily. Helped me go back and work on tweaks. Having such solid batting stock to bowl to in